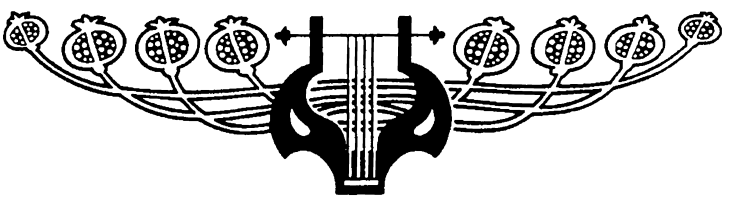
IMPROMPTU IN A—FLAT

Op. 90, No. 4

By

FRANZ PETER SCHUBERT



REVISED EDITION WITH FINGERING, PEDALING, PHRASING, AND INSTRUCTIVE ANNOTATIONS ON INTERPRETATION AND METHOD OF STUDY

By LEOPOLD GODOWSKY

FORM AND STRUCTURE AND HARMONIC ANALYSIS

By EDGAR STILLMAN KELLEY

BIOGRAPHICAL SKETCH, GENERAL INFORMATION AND GLOSSARY

By EMERSON WHITHORNE

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IMPROMPTU IN A FLAT.

BIOGRAPHICAL SKETCH—FRANZ PETER SCHUBERT.

Born at Lichtenthal, near Vienna, January 31, 1797.
Died at Vienna, November 19, 1828.

FRANZ PETER SCHUBERT was not only the most prolific song-writer in tho history of music, but undoubtedly he was the greatest of song-writers. His versatility of expression was astounding and his technic in the song-form extraordinary. In his orchestral and chamber works he frequently neglected the structure and often compressed too much material into one composition; his very spontaneity was here somewhat of a drawback, a quality however absolutely essential in song-writing.

The child of humble parents, he lived a short life without any of the world's luxuries; but that he was ever abjectly poor is to be doubted. He was able to assist his father, who was the parish schoolmaster, by teaching one of the lower classes, and when this was no longer possible he gave a few piano lessons at the country-seats of the aristocracy. But he was not able to enjoy the society of the wealthy, for his nature was a naive, unsophisticated one which was only happy among the common people.

Franz was first taught the violin by his father, while his brother Ferdinand assisted him with the rudiments of piano-playing; later Michael Holzer, the parish choir-master, gave him a more complete understanding of music as an art. At eleven years of age he was already first soprano in the choir and had begun composing. He became a pupil of the Imperial School for the education of choristers in 1808, at which institution he was instructed in music and the common branches; here he also became familiar with the classical masters through playing first-violin in the school orchestra. Indeed we find the precocious youth conducting when Rucziszka, the leader, was absent. Even his Sundays and holidays were spent in quartet playing with his father and brothers.

At this time Schubert had difficulty in obtaining music paper for recording his youthful inspirations; so poor was his family that one of his school-friends came forward and agreed to keep him provided with writing materials. It is difficult to realize that at the age of twenty-five Schubert was little known outside a small circle of admirers in Vienna. It was then that Count Dietrichstein arranged a small syndicate to publish a few Schubert songs. These were sufficiently successful to ensure a further risk, and gradually the publisher, Diabelli, became interested and eventually brought out some of his works.

Although influenced by Mozart, Schubert's great admiration was for Beethoven; he looked upon him as a sort of deity, and when his publisher took him to meet the master he was so shy that he was unable to say more than a few words.

Schubert's plan of daily life was exceedingly simple. Arising early he would compose until 2 o'clock in the afternoon, when he would go into the country, or to some restaurant to meet his friends. He must have been a lovable nature, for he seemed never to lack friends who paid him homage.

Undoubtedly he often composed too quickly and perhaps he selected the texts of some of his songs without sufficient discrimination. We know that he sometimes wrote eight songs in one day, which seems miraculous.

His death was sudden, caused by a nervous fever, and when one considers that he was then only thirty-one years of age, one wonders what the world might have possessed had his brother Ferdinand been able to nurse him back to health.

POETIC IDEA.—Schubert's ideas were always so spontaneous and so quickly put on paper that his felicity in his Impromptus is easily explained. They were musical fragments of thought which he probably spent little time in welding together. The middle section of this particular Impromptu is peculiarly Schubertian in its melodic contour and harmonic coloring. One need explain no subjective idea into the composition, for it is unlikely that Schubert intended any.

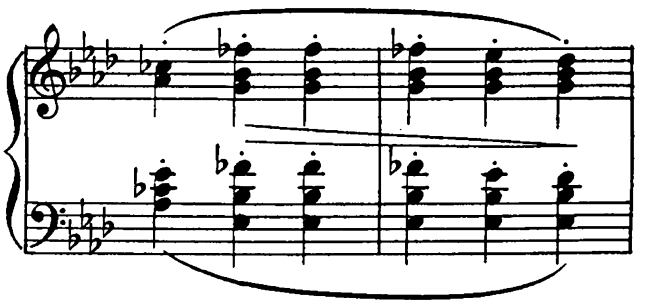
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METHOD OF STUDY.—As the first four measures of the right hand consist only of passages based on common chords, the left hand must receive careful attention. The middle voice of the chord which enters on the second beat of the first measure is the only one which progresses melodically, hence this note must be made to sound out above the two outside voices, as must the B flat in the succeeding chord.

Note that the syncopation and resolution of the inner voice gives a sighing effect to these chords. The student should bring out the first note of the descending passages and not neglect the accented notes which make an imitative echo of the left hand resolution mentioned above. Schubert marked a *decrescendo* from the second chord of the fifth measure, as he wished this and the sixth measure phrased melodically thus:—



Naturally analogous measures receive similar treatment. It may be remarked that in some editions the metrical phrasing is employed which brings a *crescendo* in the fifth measure and a *diminuendo* in the sixth measure, as follows:—



This metrical phrasing follows the rhythmic pulse of the composition, as expressed in the time signature.

The top voices of these chord sections should be brought out a little in both hands. Whereas there should be a slight break at the end of each descending right-hand passage, one should be cautious not to allow any cleft to exist between the last chord of the chord-phrases and the first note of the descending patterns, for the top voice of the chords leads naturally to the first of these passages. Also play the measures of chords, wherever they occur, always a little louder than the preceding measures.

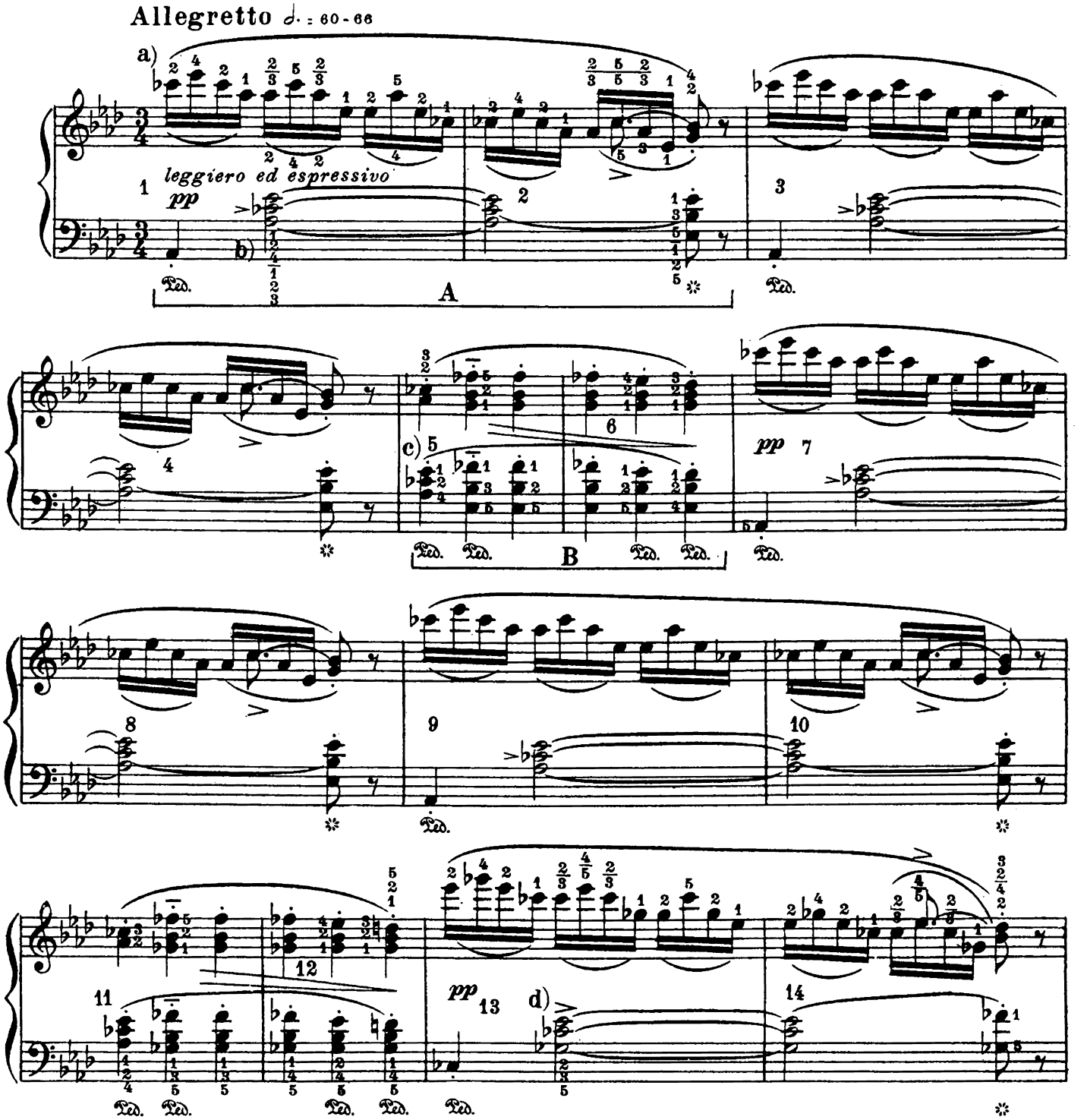
The enharmonic change is worthy of remark at measure 27, as Schubert was one of the first to make profuse use of this idea. Note the phrasing in the left hand in measures 47, 48, 49 and 50. At measure 72 the clever use of the opening motive of the preceding theme has produced a beautiful phrase, which must be given very tenderly. Although measure 107 is marked "p," the melody note above must sound out audibly, with the chords underneath subdued in tone quality. Nevertheless, let the student not neglect to make a *crescendo* with these chords to sufficiently support the *crescendos* in the melody. The editor has added an effective Ossia at measure 169, of which the student is advised to avail himself. It averts monotony in the left hand.

Special emphasis is laid upon the value of a thorough comprehension of the form and harmony of the compositions under consideration. This not only widens the intellectual horizon of the student, but it enables him to appreciate many fine points of structure too often overlooked. Furthermore, it impels him to interpret the thought of the composer with a fidelity otherwise beyond his grasp. Finally, it gives him a logical method of memorizing and reading at sight.

Impromptu.

Edited by Leopold Godowsky.

Fr. Schubert, Op. 90 No. 4.



a) The sixteenths fast, light, smooth and even.

b) The C♭ leading to the B♭ must be emphasized.

c) All measures containing quarter-notes must be played slower and with expression in the upper notes of both hands.
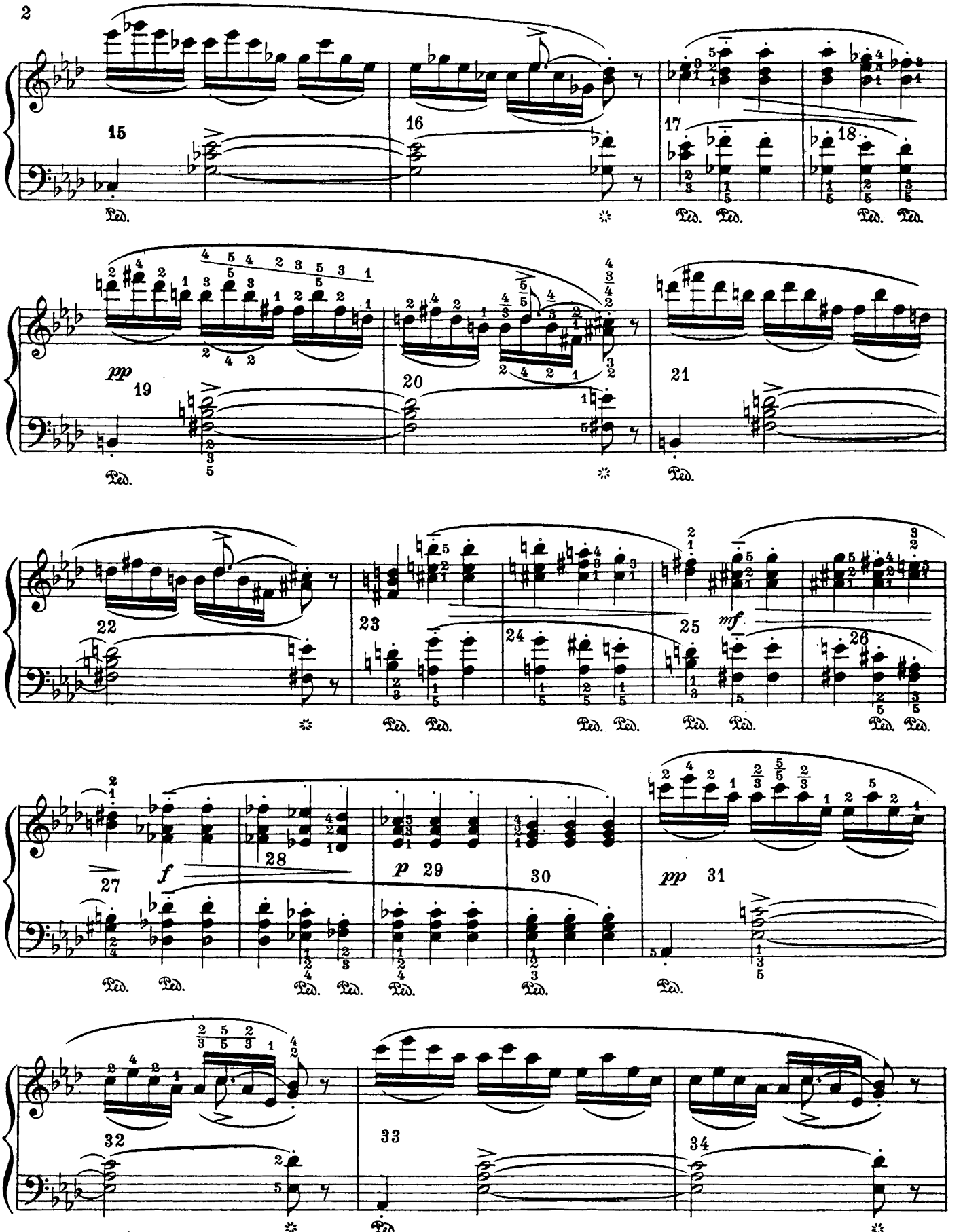
d) In the next two measures and in all similar places, the upper voice of the left hand is to be brought out.
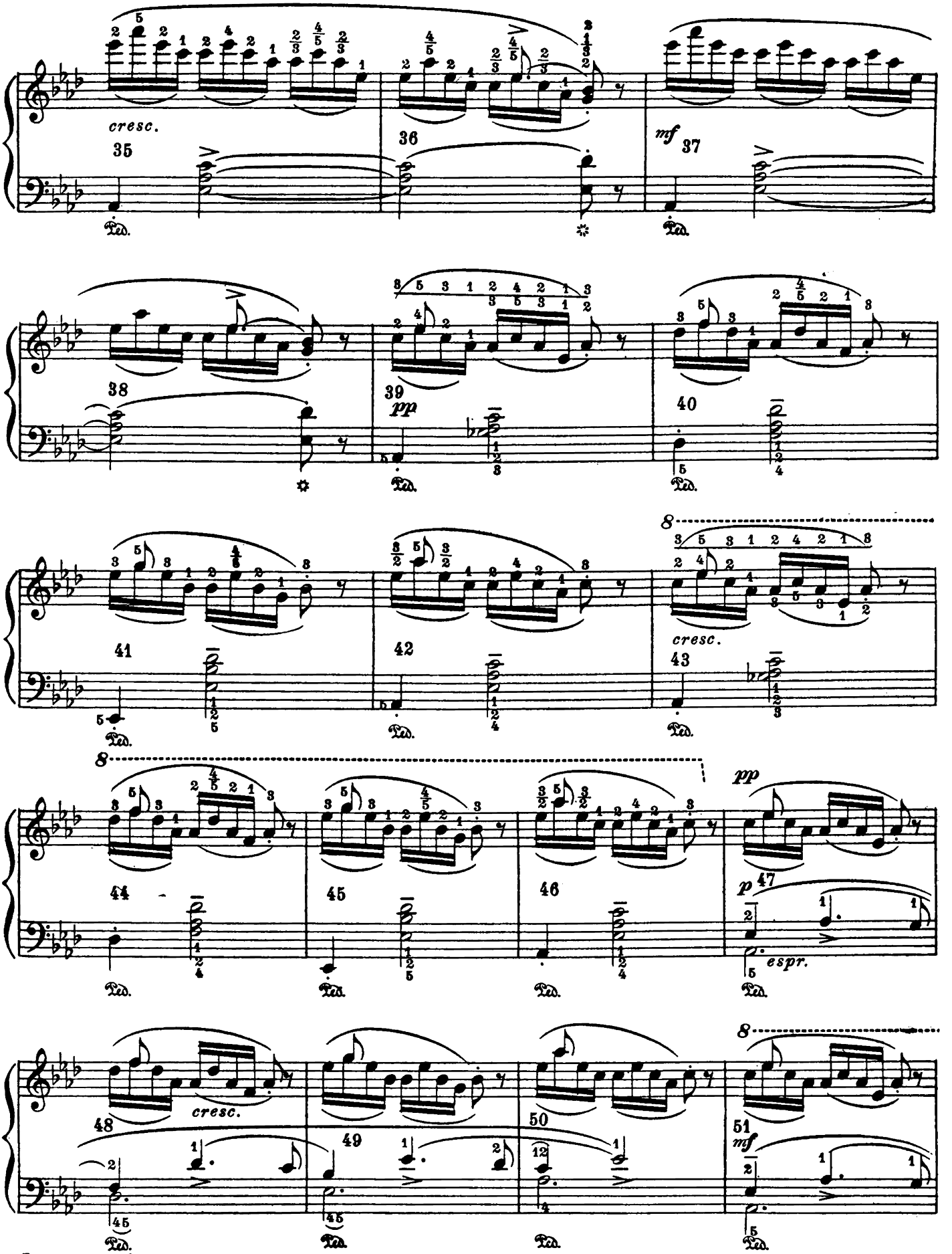
A and **B** refer to the structure. See notes on form page.
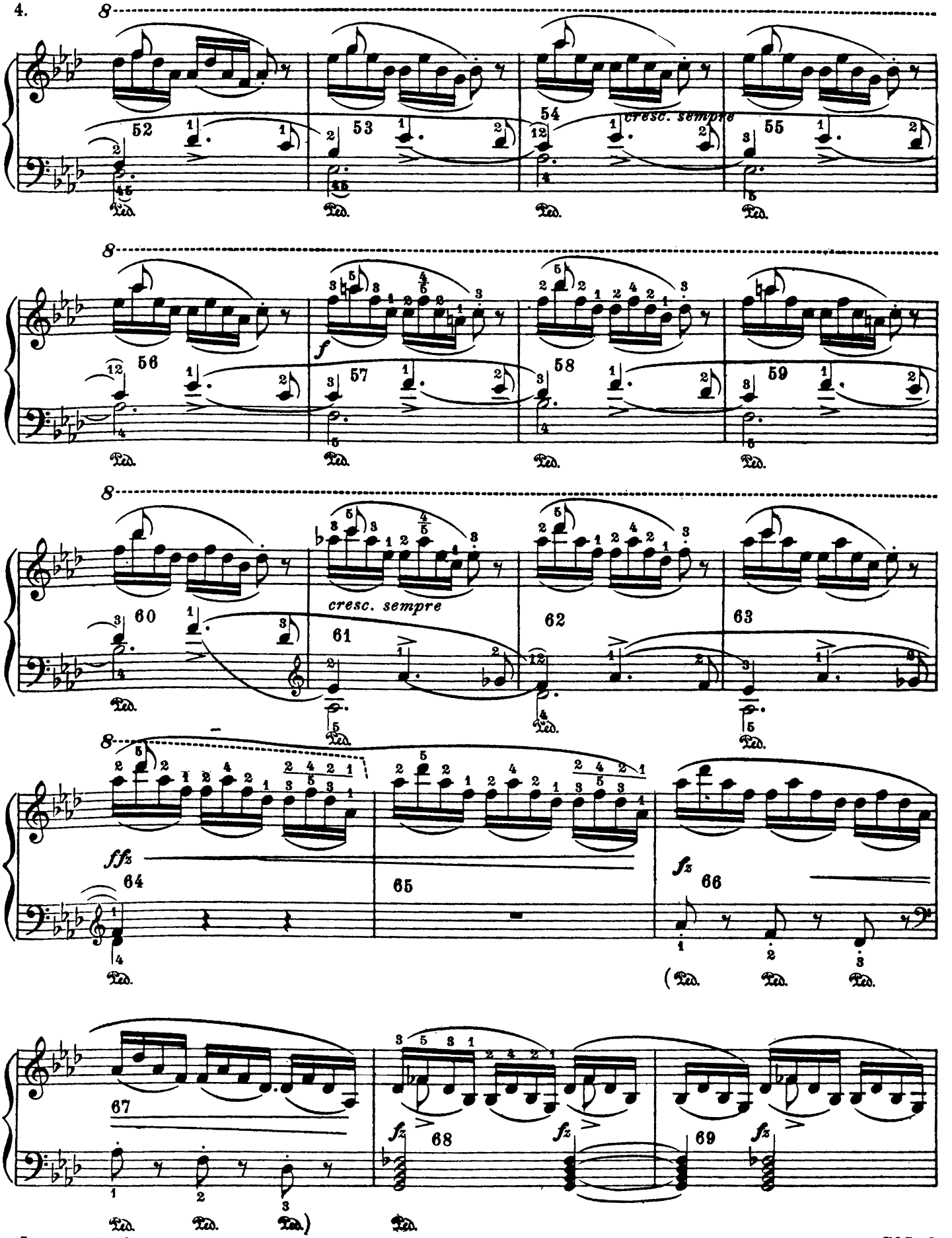
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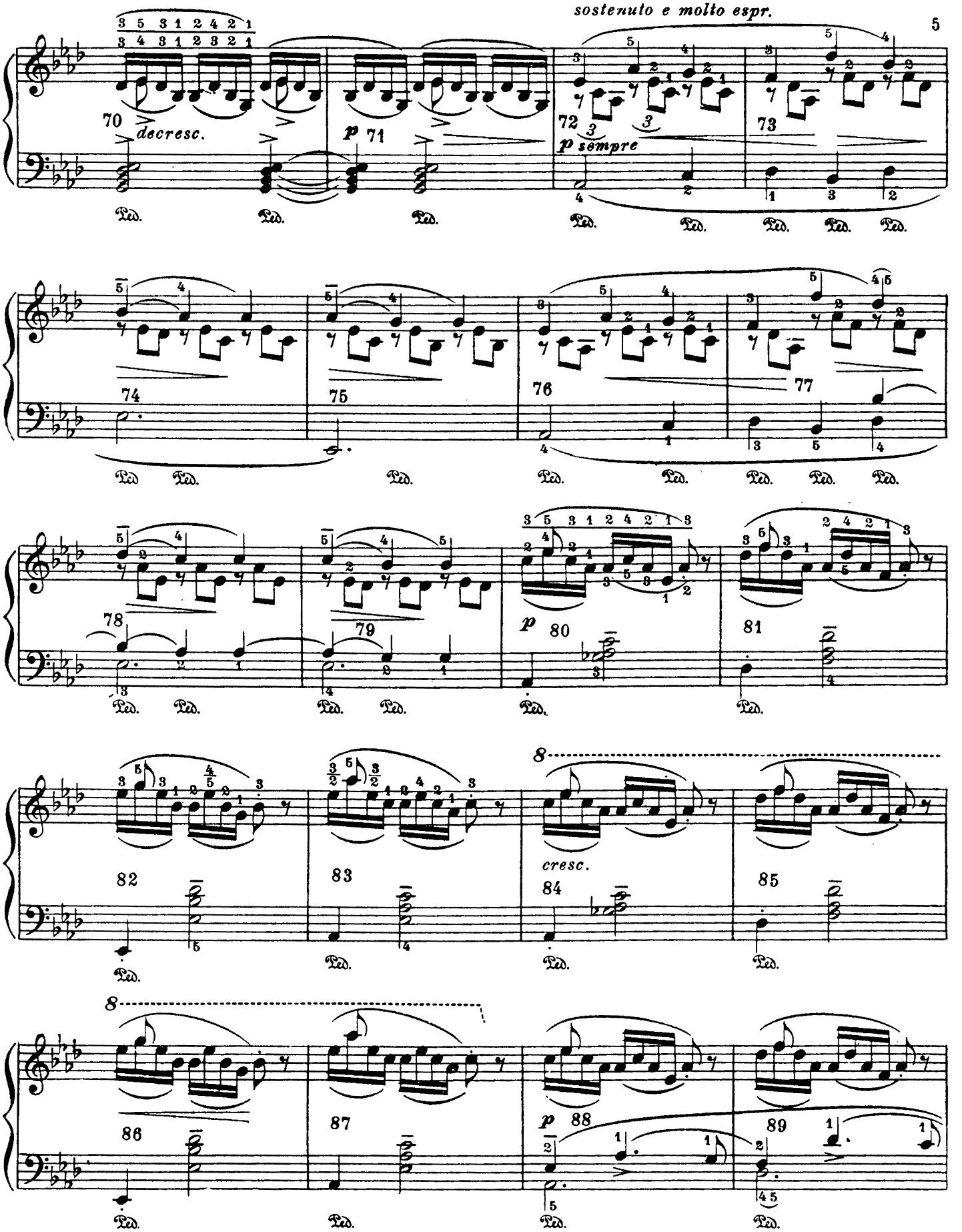
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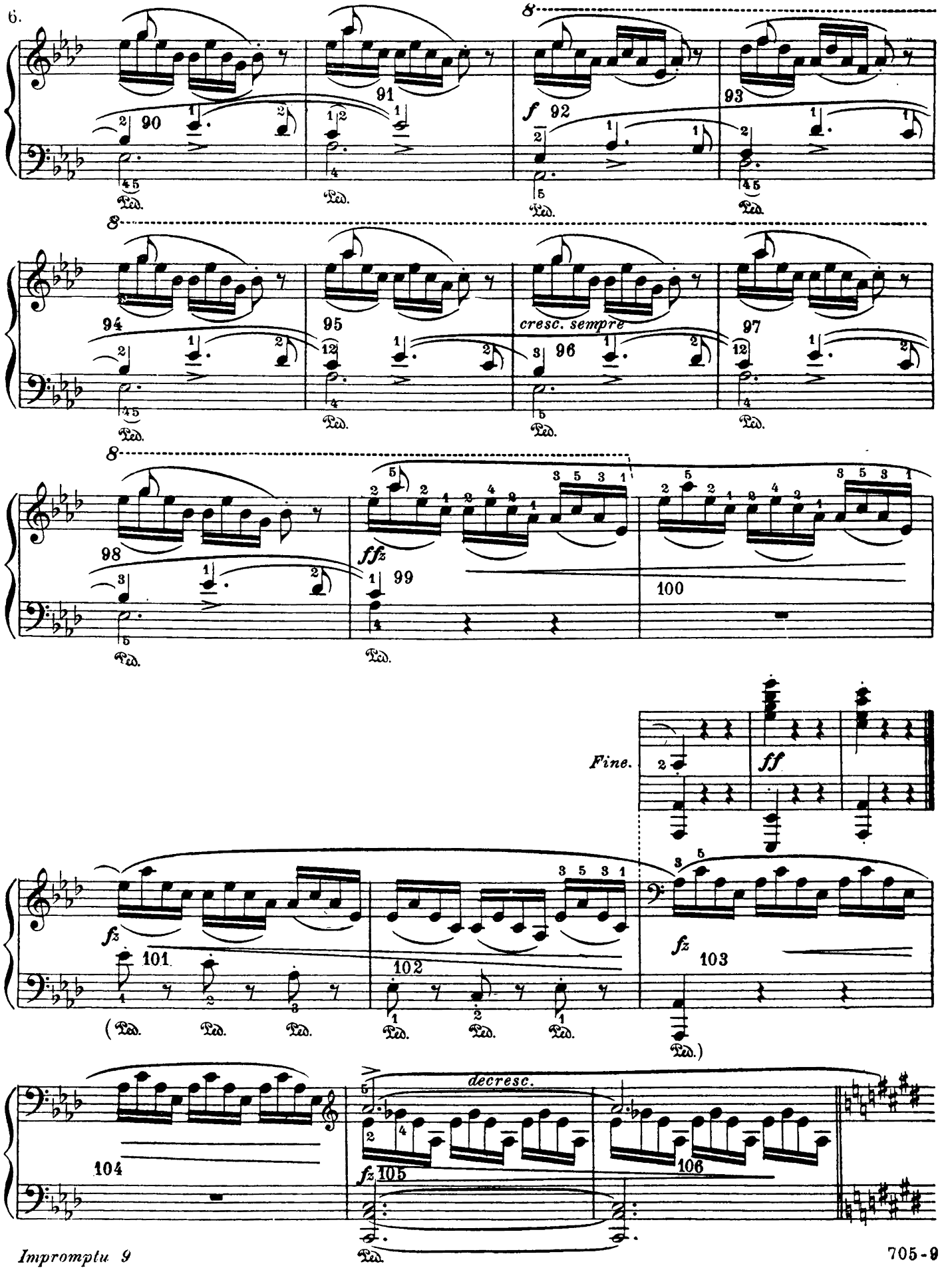
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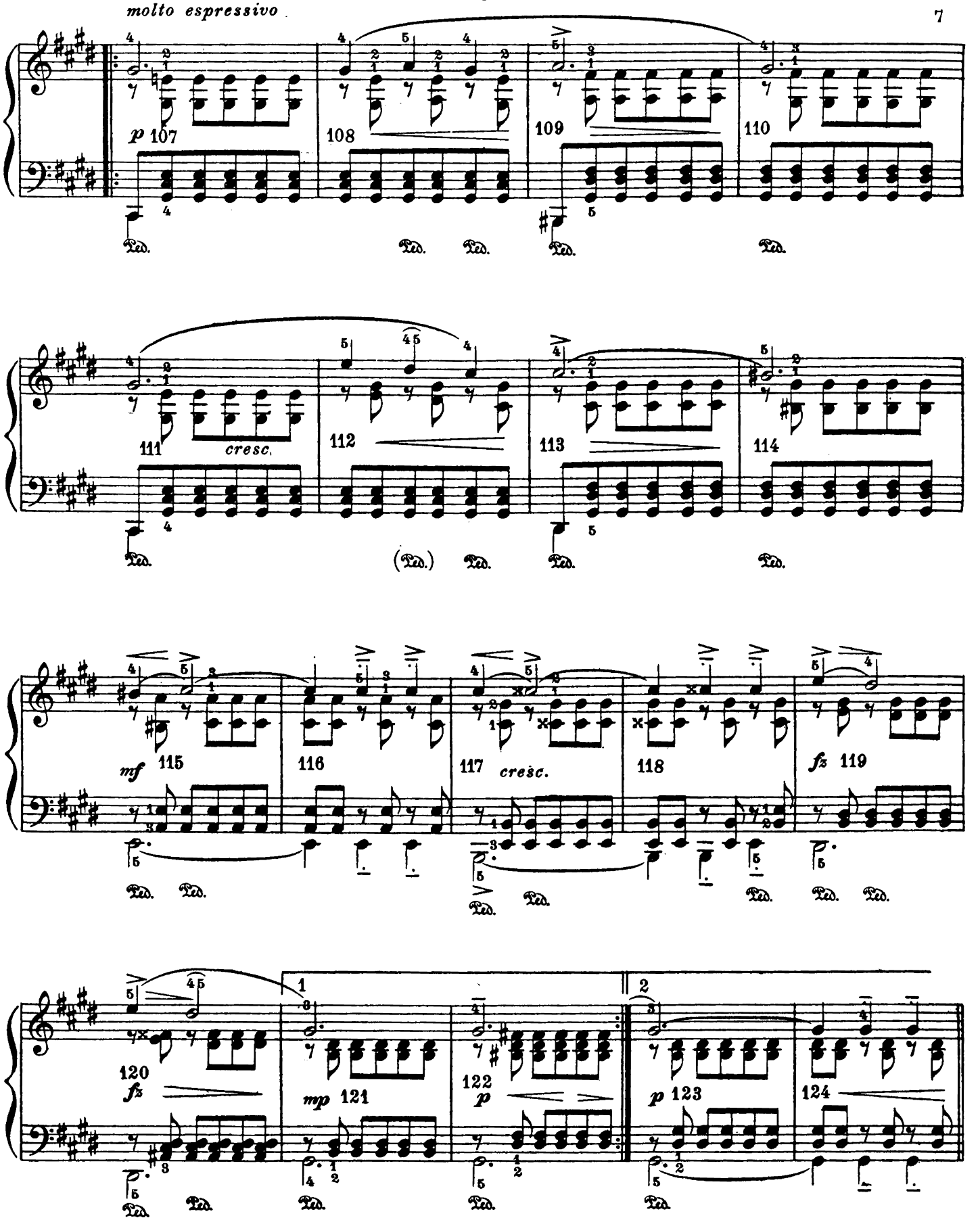

15
16
17
18
Ped.
pp
19
20
21
22
23
24
25
mf
26
27
f
28
p
29
30
pp
31
32
33
34
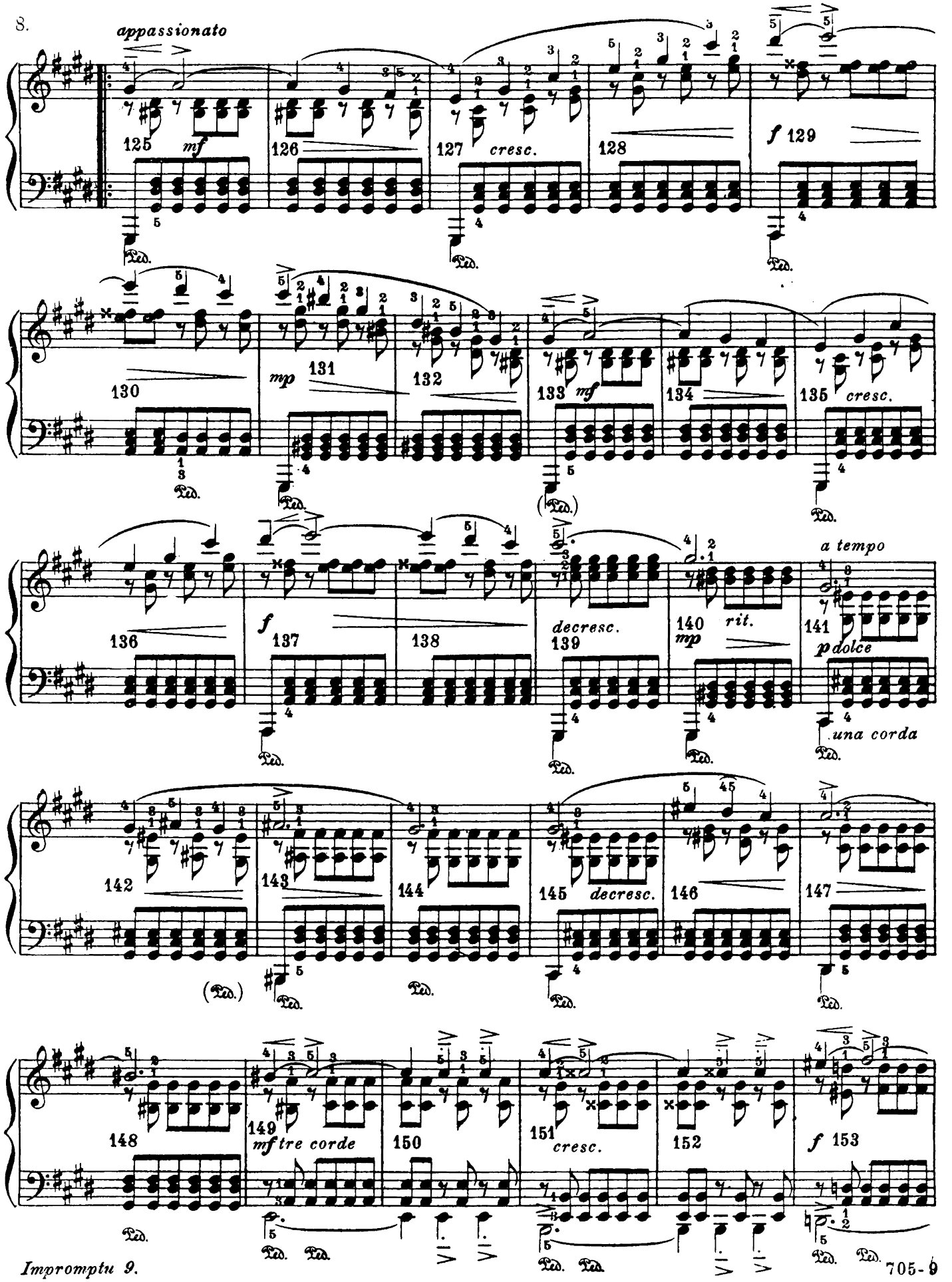

cresc.
35
36
mf
37
38
39
pp
40
41
42
cresc.
43
44
45
46
pp
p
espr.
47
48
cresc.
49
50
51
mf

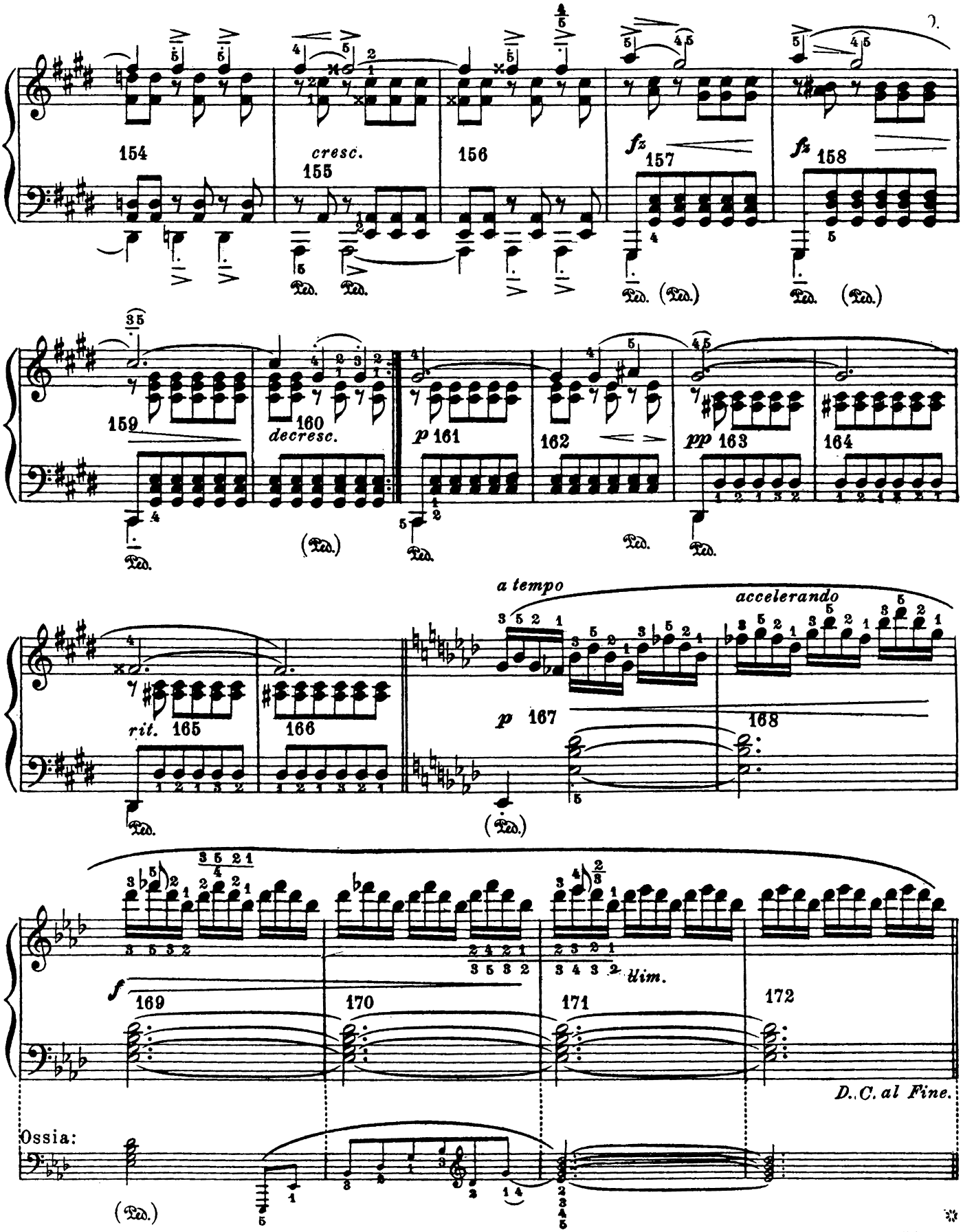

4.
8
52
53
54
cresc. sempre
55
56
f
57
58
59
60
cresc. sempre
61
62
63
ffz
64
65
fz
66
67
fz
68
fz
69
fz
Ped.


sostenuto e molto espr.
70
decresc.
p 71
72
p sempre
73
74
75
76
77
78
79
p 80
81
8
cresc.
82
83
84
85
8
86
87
p 88
89


6.
8
90
91
f 92
93
Ped.
8
94
95
cresc. sempre
96
97
8
98
ffz
99
100
Fine.
ff
fz
101
102
fz
103
(Ped.)
104
decresc.
fz
105
106


molto espressivo
p 107
108
109
110
111
cresc.
112
113
114
mf 115
116
117 cresc.
118
fz 119
120
fz
1
mp 121
122
p
2
p 123
124


appassionato
125 mf
126
127 cresc.
128
f 129
130
mp 131
132
133 mf
134
135 cresc.
136
f 137
138
decresc. 139
140 rit.
mp
a tempo
141 p dolce
una corda
142
143
144
145 decresc.
146
147
148
149 mf tre corde
150
151 cresc.
152
f 153


154
cresc.
155
156
fz
157
fz
158
159
160
decresc.
p
161
162
pp
163
164
rit.
165
166
a tempo
accelerando
p
167
168
f
169
170
171
172
Ulim.
D. C. al Fine.
Ossia: